HOW NITISH HAS GAINED THE UPPER HAND IN BIHAR

- His decision to enumerate castes in the state has the BJP scurrying behind Nitish, as the exercise is likely to stir the social pot and consolidate caste groups, which may overpower religious polarisation or hypernationalism in the election
- The emergence of Tejashwi Yadav, already a significant challenger in the 2020 assembly poll and getting stronger, makes it necessary for the BJP to be with a formidable ally like Nitish rather than go it alone
- The JD(U)-RJD collaboration on a caste census for Bihar has opened the possibility for an alternative alliance should the BJP step on his toes. Hence the saffron party's wooing of Nitish
- Nitish's denial of a Rajya Sabha nomination to R.C.P. Singh has put paid to any attempt to create a parallel power centre in the JD(U)
- With the LJP a divided house and Chirag and Pashupati Paras going in opposite directions, the BJP cannot take the Paswan voters for granted in 2024 as they could in 2019
- Though the BJP has gained in strength in the Bihar assembly by poaching the three MLAs of Mukesh Sahni's Vikassheel Insaan Party, its miserable loss in the Bochaha assembly bypoll in April came as a rude shock

of 2019 in 2024 is far more realistic than with any misadventure of putting up a BJP CM." The NDA had won 39 out of Bihar's 40 Lok Sabha seats in 2019—and despite the Janata Dal (United)'s depleted vote and seat share in the 2020 assembly polls, the BJP will need Nitish's sheen for 2024.

RETURN TO RECKONING

Two factors have contributed to Nitish's renewed relevance. One, his dogged pursuit of caste enumeration in the state for better targeting of government schemes. Going by the feedback from the countryside, this initiative has helped consolidate the otherwise reluctant extremely backward class groups to rally behind him. Timing is a factor here. Nitish has promised to finish the caste count by February 2023 and make the results public. This is expected to trigger a new caste-driven momentum in the run-up to 2024. If the BJP has been accused of using nationalist sentiments and religious polarisation for electoral dividends, the caste count could result in a social churn that's likely to benefit regional parties more than the BJP (or the Congress). Caste being a slippery slope, a national party like the BJP may like to play it safe and bat behind a consummate practitioner of social engineering like Nitish.

Two, the BJP's principal opponent in Bihar—Tejashwi Yadav, with his Muslim-Yadav (M-Y) vote intact and a spirited performance in the 2020 assembly polls adding wind to his sails—is in a much better position than he was in 2019, when the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) lost all seats it contested. If the BJP has to fight him, they will again need Nitish on their side. Over the years, if the RJD's formidable M-Y combination (16 per cent Muslim vote and 14 per cent Yadav) has failed to stop Nitish, it's largely because the Bihar CM himself has a similar cohort of EBCs and Mahadalits behind him. Despite the BJP touching the highest vote share in Bihar, it's not enough for them to go it alone if the contest is bipolar. The BJP swept Bihar in the 2014 Lok Sabha polls when the contest was triangular and both Nitish and RJD were fighting alone and against each other. BJP Rajya Sabha member Sushil Modi has always said Bihar has three major political forces—the BJP, the JD(U) and the RJD. When any two join hands, they defeat the third. If Nitish crosses sides, the saffron party may face a repeat of 2015. That's when Nitish joined hands with the RJD and Congress in a *mahagathbandhan* (grand alliance) to secure an absolute majority, with the BJP securing just 53 seats in the 243-member assembly.

Even if the outcome of the caste count is a further fragmentation of Bihar's electorate, it's expected to suit Nitish, who has cleverly synced development with targeted social welfare for marginalised groups. That blend has kept the Mahadalit vote with him and weaned away Muslims characterised as EBCs away from the RJD as well as a section of the BJP's urban middle class, *savarna* vote. The EBCs, consisting of over 100 castes and constituting 30 per cent of Bihar's population, have come to have a substantial voice in Bihar's political space. There's not much evidence-based mapping of EBC voting preferences since they are usually silent voters and not an assertive monolith like the *savarnas* or Yadavs, but a majority among them are believed to back Nitish.

WHEEL OF COALITION DHARMA

What also worries the BJP is the fact that Nitish and Tejashwi have been warming up to each other ever since finding common ground in the caste census. As Dr Nawal Kishore Choudhary, retired head of the economics department at Patna University, says, "It's not difficult to understand why the JD(U) and RJD, which claim to represent the marginalised communities, have been the biggest proponents of the caste census. It helps strengthen their identity politics; a party like the BJP, on the other hand, may stand weakened." JD(U) leaders have been restrained against the RJD of late, a clear signal to the BJP that Nitish retains the potential to explore other options for alliance. That explains why the BJP is suddenly all milk and honey.

Nitish's return to prominence in state politics was not a given after the 2020 assembly polls: the NDA had barely scraped through with a slender majority. The JD(U)'s own tally had dropped from 71 seats in 2015 to 43—way below the BJP's 74 (up from 53).